

Word family: **soon / sooner / soonest**

Base word: soon

Comparative: sooner

Superlative: soonest

Part of speech: adverb (副詞)

Your sentence:

> “Then, **as soon as** they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

A useful point first: **soon** itself does not have many genuinely separate modern meanings. Its core idea is consistently **「在很短時間內／較早」**. The richness comes mainly from several very common grammatical patterns and fixed expressions.

Meaning in this passage

Here, **as soon as** means **immediately when / immediately after** one event happens.

繁體中文: 某件事一發生, 另一件事便立即或幾乎立即發生

中文翻譯:

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

「然後, 他們一戴上耳機, 周圍的一切似乎便立即淡到背景中, 不再那麼引人注意。」

as soon as = 一……就……; 某事一發生, 另一件事便隨即發生

1. **soon** = after a short time (從現在或某個時間點起不久) — 很快; 不久後

Meaning: After only a short period of time.

Practice 1

> “The train will arrive **soon**.”

「火車很快便會到達／不久後便會到達。」

Practice 2

> “She returned to work **soon** after the meeting.”

「會議結束後**不久**，她便回去工作。」

soon = 從現在或某個參考時間點開始計算，只需經過很短時間便發生

2. **as soon as + clause (某件事一發生) — 一.....就.....; 一旦.....便立即.....**

This is the meaning in your original sentence.

Meaning: Immediately when or immediately after something happens.

Practice 3 — Original

> “**As soon as** they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

「他們**一戴上耳機**，周圍的一切似乎便淡到背景中。」

Practice 4

> “Call me **as soon as** you arrive.”

「你**一到達就立即**打電話給我。」

Practice 5

> “The room became quiet **as soon as** the teacher entered.”

「老師**一走進來，房間便立即安靜下來**。」

as soon as = 前一件事一發生，後一件事便立即或幾乎立即發生

3. **as soon as possible — 儘快; 在最早可行時間內**

Meaning: At the earliest practical or possible time.

Practice 6

> “Please reply **as soon as possible**.”

「請**儘快／在最早可行時間內**回覆。」

Practice 7

> “We need to fix the problem **as soon as possible**.”

「我們需要**儘快**解決這個問題。」

as soon as possible = 在實際情況容許下, 以最短時間完成某事

Common abbreviation:

ASAP = as soon as possible

4. **sooner** = at an earlier time (比較而言更早) — 更早; 較早

Meaning: Earlier than another time or earlier than expected.

Practice 8

> “I expected the delivery tomorrow, but it arrived **sooner**.”

「我原本預計明天送到, 但它**更早**便到了。」

Practice 9

> “Can we meet **sooner** than Friday?”

「我們可以在星期五之前**更早**見面嗎？」

sooner = 與另一個時間相比, 在較早的時間發生

5. **the sooner + clause, the better/easier/etc.** — 越早.....越好/越容易.....

Meaning: The earlier something happens, the more desirable the result will be.

Practice 10

> “The **sooner** we leave, the better.”

「我們**越早**出發越好。」

Practice 11

> “The **sooner** you report the problem, the easier it will be to fix.”

「你**越早**報告問題, 就**越容易**解決。」

the sooner..., the... = 某事發生得越早, 另一個結果便越有利／越明顯

6. **sooner or later** — 遲早; 最終總會發生

This is a very common fixed expression.

Meaning: Eventually, although the exact time is unknown.

Practice 12

> “**Sooner or later**, we’ll have to replace this computer.”

「**遲早**我們都要更換這部電腦。」

Practice 13

> “The truth will come out **sooner or later**.”

「真相**遲早**總會**被**揭露。」

sooner or later = 不知道具體何時, 但最終一定會發生

Notice that this is not literally asking whether something happens “soon” or “late”; the whole phrase means **eventually**.

7. **no sooner ... than ...** — 剛一.....便.....; 一.....就.....

Meaning: One event happens immediately after another.

This is more formal/literary than **as soon as**, but still useful.

Practice 14

> “No sooner had I sat down **than** the phone rang.”

「我**剛一坐下，電話便響了**。」

Practice 15

> “No sooner had the meeting started **than** the fire alarm went off.”

「會議**才剛開始，火警鐘便響了**。」

no sooner A than B = A 才剛發生, B 便立即發生

Important grammar:

> **No sooner had + subject + past participle + than...**

Because **no sooner** is placed at the beginning, formal English uses **inversion**.

> “No sooner **had I arrived** than...”

not:

> “No sooner I had arrived...” ❌

8. **too soon = earlier than appropriate/expected — 太早; 時機尚未成熟**

Meaning: Earlier than is suitable, desirable, or expected.

Practice 16

> “It is **too soon** to make a decision.”

「現在作決定**還太早，時機尚未成熟**。」

Practice 17

> “We celebrated **too soon**.”

「我們**太早便開始慶祝**了。」

too soon = 發生的時間比適當、預期或理想時間更早

9. **so soon = unexpectedly early / after such a short time — 這麼快; 這麼早**

Meaning: After a surprisingly short period of time.

Practice 18

> “I didn’t expect you back **so soon**.”

「我沒想到你**這麼快便回來**。」

Practice 19

> “Why are you leaving **so soon**?”

「你為甚麼**這麼早／這麼快就要離開**？」

so soon = 所需時間比說話者預期更短, 因此令人覺得很快或很早

10. **how soon = how much time before something happens — 還要多久; 最快甚麼時候**

Meaning: Asking how short the waiting time will be before an event happens.

Practice 20

> “**How soon** can you finish the report?”

「你**最快甚麼時候／還要多久**可以完成報告？」

Practice 21

> “**How soon** will the doctor be available?”

「醫生**還要多久才有空**？」

how soon = 詢問距離某件事發生還需要多長時間

11. **would sooner + verb = would rather (較願意……) — 寧願; 倒寧可**

This is worth including because it is a genuine extended use of **sooner**, although it is more common in British and

somewhat formal English.

****Meaning:**** Would prefer to do one thing rather than another.

Practice 22

> “I’d ****sooner**** stay home than go out in this weather.”

「這種天氣下，我****寧願留在家裡，也不想外出****。」

Practice 23

> “She’d ****sooner**** resign than accept those conditions.”

「她****寧願辭職，也不願接受那些條件****。」

****would sooner do A than B = 相比 B, 更願意選擇 A****

In everyday English, ****would rather**** is more common:

> “I’d rather stay home.”

Important distinction: ****soon vs early****

These are easily confused.

****soon****

= after a short amount of time

> “I’ll call you ****soon****.”

「我****很快／不久後****會打電話給你。」

****early****

= before the usual, expected, or scheduled time

> “I arrived ****early****.”

「我****比預定／正常時間早****到。」

So:

> “The train will arrive soon.”

means the waiting time is short.

> “The train arrived early.”

means it arrived ****before its scheduled time****.

Important distinction: **soon vs quickly******

**soon******

focuses on ****when something happens****

> “She’ll reply soon.”

「她不久後會回覆。」

**quickly******

focuses on ****how fast an action is performed****

> “She replied quickly.”

「她很快便完成了回覆這個動作。」

Compare:

> “He will eat soon.”

> = 他****不久後****會吃東西。

> “He eats quickly.”

> = 他****吃得很快****。

Very different.

Important distinction: **as soon as vs when******

when

Simply tells us one event happens at the time of another.

> “Call me **when** you arrive.”

「你到達時打電話給我。」

as soon as

adds the idea of **no unnecessary delay**

> “Call me **as soon as** you arrive.”

「你**一到達就立即**打電話給我。」

So **as soon as** is stronger and more immediate.

Important grammar note: future after **as soon as**

After **as soon as**, English normally uses the **present tense** for future meaning:

> “I’ll call you **as soon as I arrive**.” 

not normally:

> “I’ll call you as soon as I **will arrive**.” 

Likewise:

> “As soon as she **finishes**, we’ll leave.”

「她一完成, 我們便離開。」

Master comparison

Form / pattern MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning	
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soon	從現在或某參考時間點起, 只經過很短時間便發生
as soon as	前一件事一發生, 另一件事便立即或幾乎立即發生

as soon as possible	在實際情況容許下, 以最早可行時間完成	
sooner	與另一個時間相比更早發生	
the sooner..., the...	某事發生得越早, 另一個結果便越有利／越明顯	
sooner or later	雖然時間不確定, 但最終一定會發生	
no sooner...than...	前一件事才剛發生, 後一件事便立即發生	
too soon	比適當、理想或預期時間更早	
so soon	經過的時間比預期短, 令人覺得「這麼快」	
how soon	詢問距離某件事發生還需要多長時間	
would sooner	相比另一選擇, 更願意做某事; 寧願	

For your original sentence

> “Then, **as soon as** they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

The exact meaning is:

****as soon as = 某件事一發生, 另一件事便立即或幾乎立即發生****

So here:

****as soon as they put the headphones on = 他們一戴上耳機, 接下來的效果便立即出現****